

Speech recognition is another aspect that has been stuck on the 99 per cent accuracy mark for a long time. Actually, it's easy to trip up such software when you consciously try to—just throw a tongue-twister at them for fun and see what happens. The same goes for gesture recognition—whether hand or eye movements are being tracked—accuracy is nowhere near perfect. AI has a big role to play here as well...

Unfortunately, as in some other categories, when it comes to AI, our Sixth Sense is quite numb. We really don't see any revolutionary breakthroughs in the near future. Simulated AI will gradually get better, software will appear to keep getting a little smarter, but we're very, very far from software that can truly help us with our work, and help us make decisions. Not every area of technology has a rosy future, and AI is one of those that don't. ☒

Cross-Platform/Seamless Applications

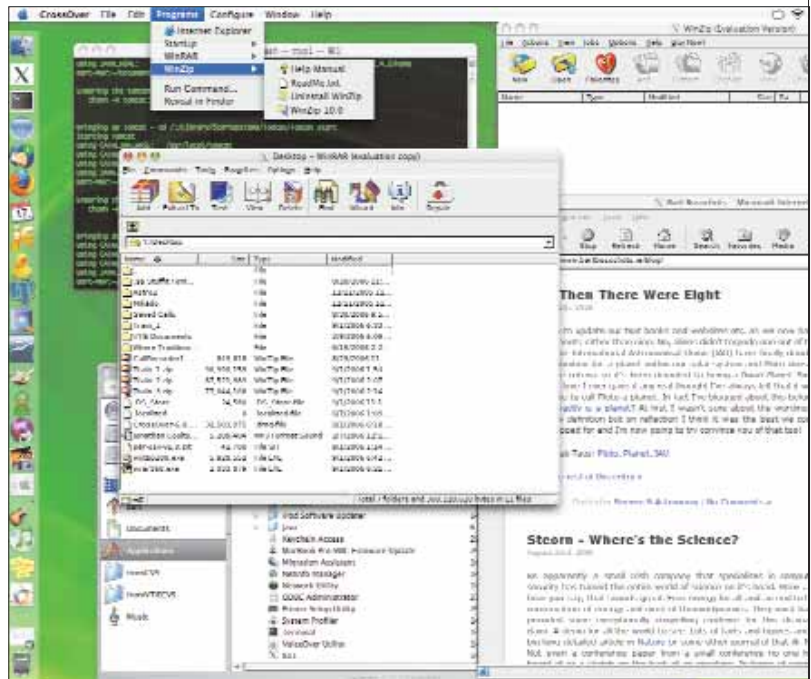
Why limit software to operating systems or platforms?

The problem with the software world today is that they're platform-dependent. Not all of them, but the majority. Applications are being made as Windows-only, or Mac-only. Linux, being open source, has a lot of applications built for it with source code available. Thus, open source applications generally are available as source, Linux binaries and Windows binaries. In a sense, open source is more cross-platform than closed source applications—a generalisation, but the numbers support it.

It's a problem that doesn't seem to be solvable—Microsoft will release application programming interfaces (APIs) to developers, but they're obviously not going to release source code. Cross-platform applications need to run on a different layer from the OS, something that is installable on any OS—something like Sun's Java, which runs anywhere, and allows Java-based applications to be run on any operating system. Java has invaded the mobile phone markets as well, and anything from games to software applications are now installable on your phone.

Another truly cross-platform way of developing applications is to develop them online. Applications such as Google's Docs and Spreadsheets, Calendar, etc., are good because they're cross-platform. It's very useful to have such applications when working across a large group of people, because you need not worry about what OS they're running. Our Sixth Sense tells us we can expect to see applications in general move a wee bit closer to offering cross-platform support. And you don't need to play soothsayer to say that applications being made into Web-based services will also increase in popularity.

We mentioned WinFS earlier in this section, and a filesystem like it could really help in turning data into seamless streams that are accessible by any platform. Application com-



Crossover running native Windows programs on a Mac

patibility on different platforms will be harder to achieve, because they have to be coded that way, but Microsoft has started the ball rolling by supporting the Open Document Format (ODF) (www.oasis-open.org) in Microsoft Office. This standardises all office suites that use this format, allowing access to office documents to any office application on any platform.

The future here is garbled, and our Sixth Sense tells us that if the big names collaborate, the difference between the platforms—in terms of usability and the ability to access data—will get minimal. ☒